

Summer Squash (Courgette)

CULTIVARS

- Romanesco
- Zephyr
- Safari
- Gold Mine

INTENSIVE SPACING

- 1 row per bed every 24" (60 cm) on the row

FERTILIZATION

- Summer squash do well in beds amended with lots of compost, fresh or aged. The rule of thumb is to spread 1 inch (5 cm) in the middle of the bed. Since it's a single row crop, there's no need to apply the compost on the whole width of the bed.
- When planting in beds where compost was applied in the previous crops, we only supplement with a mixture of alfalfa meal (2-0-2) and pelleted chicken manure (5-3-2).

IRRIGATION

Irrigation Type

- Drip tape (4 per bed) : under plastic mulch.
- No sprinkler to keep foliage dry and thus prevent diseases.

Irrigation Management

- Root depth: Medium (24"-40")
- General: Rapid growth and ongoing fruit production requires frequent deep water. Critical to water consistently at flowering and fruit development stage.

IMPLANTATION

We plan for 2 summer squash seedlings in the season and intend to harvest the plants over 10 to 12 weeks. This ensures continuous supply of well-rounded tender fruits.

EQUIPMENT

- rotary harrow
- broadfork
- 30" bed prep rake
- Landscape fabric, staples, drip tape and fittings.

TRANSPLANT ITINERARY

- Pass through with the broadfork.
- Remove large debris from the bed if needed (use flail mower, rake or manually remove the large chunks).
- Apply compost and-or amendments in the middle of the bed and pass with the rotary harrow at a depth of 2.5" (6 cm). Since the bed is covered with landscape fabric, it needs not to be clean up with another pass of the rake.
- Install 4 lines of drip tape per bed and start the system. Fix leaks at point that point, if any.
- Lay down landscape fabric and secured with staples each second step (5' or 1.5 m). It needs to be really tight.
- Transplant summer squash making sure to place them in the center of each hole. Summer squash seedlings are root-sensitive. Handle them carefully and don't bury their collars.
- Water the bed thoroughly the first time, keeping the soil moist for the first week after the transplant.

WEEDING

- No weeding required

PLANT PROTECTION

- Young summer squash plants must always be covered with an anti-insect net (or floating row cover in the spring) to prevent both the cucumber beetles and squash beetles from establishing themselves.
- When the plants begin to flower, the net must be removed. At that point, the plant is well established and should survive the presence of both the cucumber and squash beetle.

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HARVEST

- Harvesting is done every day using a field knife and tree planting bags. Long sleeves should be worn to prevent scratching of the arms.
- Courgette should measure between 5" and 7" (13 and 18 cm). Longer ones are picked, but left in the fields.
- The patty pan squash are harvested when they measure between 3" and 4" (7 and 10 cm). The zucchini can stay in the field until the person in charge of harvest comes to pick them up. However, the flowers must be brought in immediately after having been harvested.

CONDITIONING

- Summer squash are not washed, but must be wiped clean if dirty.

STORING

- Summer squash are stored in cold room keep at 47 °F (8 °C) and should not be stored for more than 4 days before being sold.